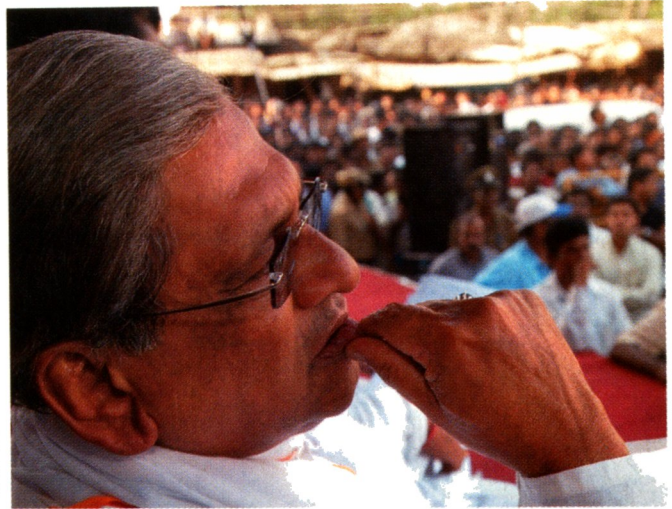
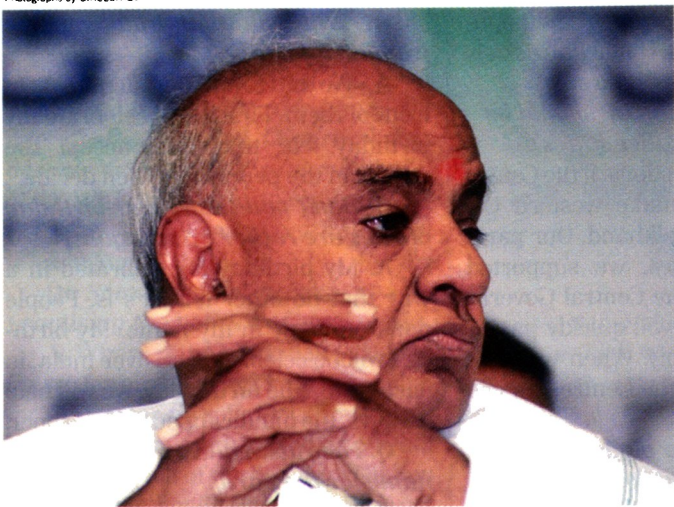


Photographs by GIREESH GV



Battle of Wills

BSP's entry in the state may upset the electoral calculations of various political parties as things take an interesting turn with a four-cornered contest becoming a distinct possibility

■ By Stephen David

For years now, there have been three main political parties in Karnataka—JD(s), Congress and BJP—that have been vying for the favour of the two main caste groups—the majority Lingayats and the second biggest caste bloc Vokkaligas. But when this past Christmas eve saw the garden city being painted literally blue, it was clear that the state was set to welcome another entity into the political arena. It was the BSP chief and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati, who had jetted into the city on a private aircraft to establish a fourth front in the state.

At a well attended rally at the 400-acre Bangalore Palace grounds, she publicly welcomed former JD(s) heavyweight P.G.R. Sindhia into her party and anointed him the national general secretary. To a 30,000-strong crowd, Mayawati thundered that the elephant—her party symbol—was ready to trample over the opposition in the state, whose 30 per cent population consists of SC/STs, backward classes and Muslims—all of whom have been traditionally with the Congress, and of late with JD(s). Sindhia is confident that BSP will be able to garner at least 8 to 10 per cent of the vote share in the upcoming polls and will be able to make a big difference in the electoral matrix.

Mayawati may have to wait a while longer to realise her ambitions but the other contenders are already gearing up for the assembly elections due in April. JD(s) patriarch H.D. Deve Gowda may be down for the moment, but the family can never be written off considering that the Vokkaligas, who form 16 per cent of the population see Gowda and his two sons—former chief

minister Kumaraswamy and minister H.D. Revanna—as their saviours. Gowda had last year strategically appointed a Muslim, Meerajuddin Patel, as the state JD(s) unit president to attract the nearly 12 per cent Muslim votes in the absence of a strong Muslim leadership in the Congress. The party, however, lost its credibility when it ditched BJP by pulling the plug on Lingayat leader B.S. Yeddyurappa and kicking him out of the chief minister's chair in just seven days in October last year. The Lingayats, forming 18 per cent of the state's population, have traditionally voted for BJP and are expected to throw their weight behind Yeddyurappa yet again, the internal schisms within the party notwithstanding. Infighting is on between Yeddyurappa and another BJP leader H.N. Ananth Kumar, who represents the minority Brahmin community.

Though the sympathy wave has died down for Yeddyurappa after the 20-month marriage between JD(s) and BJP collapsed, the saffron party still stands to gain the Lingayat votes especially in north and central Karnataka. It is now planning to wean off some votes of the other caste group and has retained a Vokkaliga, D.V. Sadananda Gowda, as the state unit president. Sadananda is seen to be Yeddyurappa's man although he himself states that the party comes first for him.

For Congress, a defeat here closely after those in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh, would be nothing less than a body blow. Its leader and former chief minister Dharam Singh points out the importance of preaching the message of stability and all-round development, something only his party can provide, which is being projected as the main part of the manifesto. The Congress is already trying to lure Maharashtra

A fractured mandate seems likely though most political parties are trying their best to reach the magic figure of 113.